it seeks to promote, are central to an understanding of what makes India India. Its characters and personages still march triumphantly in Indian minds, its myths and legends still inspire the Indian imagination, its events still speak to Indians with a contemporary resonance.

While the *Ramayana* (composed from around the 200 BCE to perhaps 200 CE) and the *Mahabharata* (said to be composed between about 400 BCE and 400 CE, after some eight centuries of retellings and interpolations)[14] are the two best-known epics whose core story (and many subsidiary tales) are widely known to practically every Indian, the Itihasas also include the *Yogavasishtha*, stories and fables imparted by the sage Vasishtha to Lord Rama, and the *Harivamsha*, which tells stories of creation and of the origins of Lord Krishna. When the *Ramayana* and the *Mahabharata* were retold in the vernacular languages, they acquired immense popularity and impact. The Kamban *Ramayana* in Tamil in the twelfth century CE, and Tulsidas's *Ramcharitmanas* in Awadhi in the sixteenth century, exalted Rama to his present place in the Hindu pantheon.

The *Mahabharata* incorporated the Bhagavad Gita, an extraordinary, inspirational and profoundly philosophical text which addresses in powerful and poetic language a basic conundrum of human existence: what human beings should do when they are pulled in contradictory directions by equally important but incompatible obligations. We are all faced in life with having to make hard choices; the Gita presents us with the searingly hard choice confronting the heroic warrior Arjuna, who finds himself on the battlefield, about to go to war, in the name of a just cause, whose triumph will involve the killing of several members of his own family. His duty and his moral commitment to one side of the battle stands against his love for his own kith and kin, whose blood he must shed, and that too in violation of the universal moral duty not to take life. But if, for this reason, he refuses to fight, his absence from the battlefield could allow the forces of unrighteousness to prevail; it would mean the victory of those who have committed wrongs, and it would violate his own duty and obligation as a warrior to deploy his martial skills in fulfilment of his duty and in defence of the right. Arjuna confesses his agonising dilemma to Lord Krishna, whose counsel makes up the bulk of